> comparable in many ways to those which existed in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries in Europe, and fraught with all the fluidity and uncertainty that characterize multipolar situations.[61]

Interdependence through institutions

It is true that large regions like Asia and the Indo-Pacific have more internally coherent subregions. These distinct subregions did not limit India in developing cultural and commercial links with Persia, the Arab world, the East African Seaboard, Southeast Asia, China, and Japan, established by Buddhists and traders alike and going back several millennia. In their modern iteration, regions or subregions tend to be composed of common markets, customs unions, and preferential or free trade arrangements, as well as including a modicum of intraregional connectivity, investments, and infrastructure building, ideally spanning the five clusters of commercial exchanges, transportation, information and communications technologies, energy, and people-to-people exchanges. The fact that the wide area of the Indo-Pacific has within it more coherent subregions or clusters of countries is a strength, not a weakness. Even if Asia is more heterogeneous than other regions, to suggest that Asian states are dissimilar in most respects, as indeed are states in other parts of the world, does not make them especially prone to conflict. Notwithstanding the security challenges in the Indo-Pacific, the mainstream within the Asian strategic community rejects the idea of the inevitability of war.

While Asia admittedly does not have a recognised regional structure that includes all the Asian states, it has several overlapping subregional, cross-regional, and regional groupings through which countries within the Indo-Pacific interact with one another. Some of these groupings and